

Donning multiple hats: Aunshuman Gaekwad played 40 Tests and 15 ODIs for India, later transitioning into roles as a national selector and eventually, the coach of the national team.

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UNFLINCHING BATTER AND A TRUSTED FRIEND

Aunshuman Gaekwad was the friend **who never said no,** always there when needed. His presence was a precious gift to cherish.

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Aunshuman Gaekwad dedicated his life to cricket. His final days were a testament to his resilience. He faced the fiercest fast bowlers on the pitch and the most dreaded opponent off it — cancer. Despite the challenges, he

never backed down and bravely bowed out.

What set Gaekwad apart was his selflessness and reliability. He was a man of few critics, known for his honesty and caring nature. He was the friend who never said no, always there when needed. His presence was a precious gift to cherish.

Mohinder Amarnath and Kapil Dev were his closest friends in the cricket

fraternity. He adored Sunil Gavaskar and GR Vishwanath. Gaekwad remained in awe of Mansur Ali Khan Pataudi, his first Test captain, and doted on Mohammad Azharuddin and Sachin Tendulkar. But he rarely talked about himself.

Pataudi was a "friendly terror." When asked to report to Pataudi in Calcutta (now Kolkata) for the Test against the West Indies in 1974,